2.7. Fermented cereal products

The term fermentation refers to the breakdown of carbohydrates into simpler substances. The advantages of fermentation are:

- Flavour and texture of the product are improved.
- Vitamin B and C content is increased.
- The product is easily digestible.
- Acid by- products formed during fermentation inhibits the growth of harmful microorganisms.
- It provides variety in the diet.

Some of the fermented cereal products are:

- Idli
- Dosai
- Dhokla
- Appam
- Bread



Fig 2.9: Fermented cereal products (Idly and Dosai)

Some fascinating facts about cereals

- The first cereal grains were domesticated by early primitive humans, about 8,000 years ago.
- The cereal industry uses 816 million pounds of sugar per year in the making of bread, biscuits and pastries.

2.8. Role of cereals in cookery

Role of cereals in cookery

1. Cereals are used as thickening agent, eg. corn flour in custard, corn flour in white sauce and macaroni in soups.
2. Cereals are used as coating agent, eg. maida paste in cutlets or bread crumbs in cutlets.
3. Cereals are used in sweet preparations, eg. rice payasam and wheat halwa.
4. Malted cereals are used in the preparation of beverages and weaning mixes.
5. Cereal products like corn flakes and rice flakes are used as ready to use foods.
6. Fermented foods made from cereals are used as breakfast foods or snacks, eg. idli, dhokla.

2.9 Health benefits of cereals

- **Source of Energy:** Cereals are the major energy provider in the diet.
- **High Mineral Content:** Ragi, millets, jowar, and bajra have high amounts of minerals and fiber.
- **Prevent Cancer:** Whole wheat products reduce the chances of breast cancer.
- **Prevent Constipation:** Cereals have both insoluble and soluble fibers like cellulose, pectin, and hemicellulose. This prevents constipation.

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